immediately to the north of the main cantonment. The noise of shooting and the plumes of smoke so close by made everyone nervous, and some of the porters and camp followers now began to break out of line and run out of the gate, leaving the baggage they were meant to be carrying and ‘mixing themselves up with the troops to the utter confusion of the whole column’.[23]

An hour later, around noon, the ghazis mounted the walls of the Mission Compound and began to fire down into the waiting troops, while the rearguard returned fire from the wallwalks of the cantonment. By one o’clock, fifty of the European infantry were lying dead or wounded in the snow. Colin Mackenzie could see that a massacre was about to take place, with the troops half in and half out of the cantonment, and, watching Elphinstone still hesitate, he galloped off in defiance of his orders – the General shouting weakly after him, ‘Mackenzie don’t do it,’ and rode to the bridge where he told Shelton to resume his march. Despite Mackenzie’s decisive action, thanks to the delay the light was fading and it was nearly five o’clock before the last sepoys of the rearguard finally left the cantonment, having manned the icy walls for eleven hours without food.[24] As they did so, the ghazis rushed straight into the empty cantonment, mounted the wallwalks and immediately began to shoot at the column from the battlements with their long jezails.

At this stage, while most of the troops were now well on their way to Bagramee, the place designated as the camp site for the first night, most of the baggage and all the ammunition of the force was still waiting to cross the bridge. As the ghazis’ jezails found their range, the camp followers and the last troops of the rearguard began to fall where they stood, first jostling then fighting in panic for their turn to cross. Amid this scene of fear,

> [Colin] Mackenzie always remembered as one of the most heart-rending sights of that humiliating day, fixing his eyes by chance on a little Hindustani child, perfectly naked, sitting on the snow, with no mother or father near it. It was a beautiful little girl about two years old, just strong enough to sit upright with her little legs doubled under her, hair curling in waving locks around the soft little throat, and her great black eyes, dilated to twice their normal size, fixed on the armed men, the passing cavalry, and all the strange sights that met her gaze . . . Many other children as young and innocent he saw slain on the road, and women with their long dark hair wet with their own blood . . . [Soon] Afghans were seen [milling in the snow, finishing off the dying and] stabbing with their knives the wounded grenadiers.[25]

Although Sturt had pointed out to the General that the river was perfectly fordable by camels and horses just upstream from the bridge, this vital piece